

FRANKLY SPEAKING

Hamid Ansari's candid remarks on the US embarrass the Government engaged in forging close ties with that country

Vice-President Hamid Ansari is known for his candour. Within months of assuming office, the former diplomat seems to have made it clear that he will not take things lying down. His recent remarks blaming US President George Bush's regime for the mess in Iraq and the rising terrorism have stirred a hornet's nest.

In an address to the Observer Research Foundation on emerging security concerns in West Asia last week, Ansari said, the US's policies of unilateralism, "creative destruction" and pre-emption had faltered. "The US has been mauled by non-state actors in Iraq. Its policies have given an impetus to terrorism. The US is highly unpopular in Muslim and Arab countries," he said. While the remarks were in the context of the situation in West Asia, that this assessment came from the Vice-President of India complicated matters.

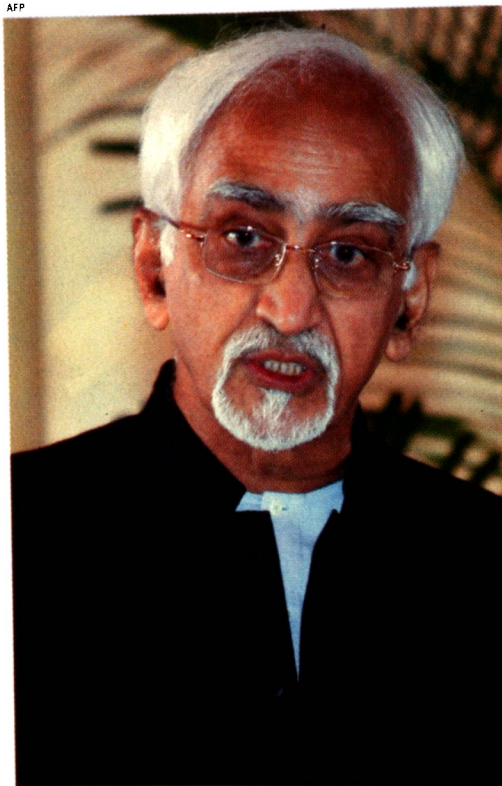
Even though the post of vice-president is a ceremonial one, the Constitution still ranks it higher than that of the prime minister. The fact that he is also the presiding officer of the Upper House, of which Prime Minister Manmohan Singh is a member, adds to its importance. The remarks have come at a time when the Parliament is debating the nuances of the Indo-US nuclear deal. Not only that, India has been invited to the Annapolis conference on the Middle East hosted by Bush to work towards a solution between Israel and Palestine.

A US diplomat was present in the audience when the remarks were made and the US mission here sent a prompt report to Washington. The Bush administration is believed to have taken up the remarks with the South Block which has had to clarify that this is not an official stand. The opinion is, however, divided within the UPA on how to rein in the vice-president who is known to speak his mind. While some senior ministers in the Government are in favour of letting the

issue die down, others are in favour of sending out a strong message "His remarks are uncalled for. He should realise he is the country's vice-president and not an academic. These remarks have put us in an embarrassing position," a minister told INDIA TODAY.

Ansari, however, is unfazed by the criticism. Sources say many in the Government, including some ministers and members of Parliament,

AFP



BAD TIMING: His statement comes when the nuclear deal is hanging fire congratulated him on his speech. But South Block is worried about the fallout. There is a fear that anti-Indian lobbies in Washington can use these remarks to embarrass the Bush regime especially if it manages to shepherd the Indo-US nuclear deal in the Congress next year. Besides, it may be used by those opposed to the country's strategic alignment with the superpower, to embarrass the Government. "The vice-president holds a consti-

tutional post and he is the president-in-waiting. He should not be making remarks that embarrass the government. The prime minister can send a message across through the President for Ansari to tone down his remarks," remarked a former cabinet secretary.

The big question is: why did the vice-president choose to speak out at this juncture. Sources say Ansari, who has expressed his reservations on the nuclear deal in the past and does not favour a strategic tilt towards the US, felt that he had to make his views clear on an important diplomatic issue. Interestingly, the vice-president had prepared this particular speech himself and was well aware of the repercussions it may have.

ANSARISPEAK

"United States today is not the sole superpower of the spring of 2003. The policies of unilateralism, creative destruction pre-emption have faltered."

"The US has been mauled by non-state actors in Iraq. Its policies have given an impetus to terrorism. It is unpopular with the Arab and Muslim countries."

"The vice-president did not say anything other than what has been said by many American scholars. These views are well known and nothing else should be read into these remarks," said an official. While Ansari has made his point of view clear, it remains to be seen if this was intended as a warning bell for the Government to do a course correction on its foreign policy, or if it was more serious and pointed to a gathering storm which may harm the UPA regime in the days to come.

by Saurabh Shukla